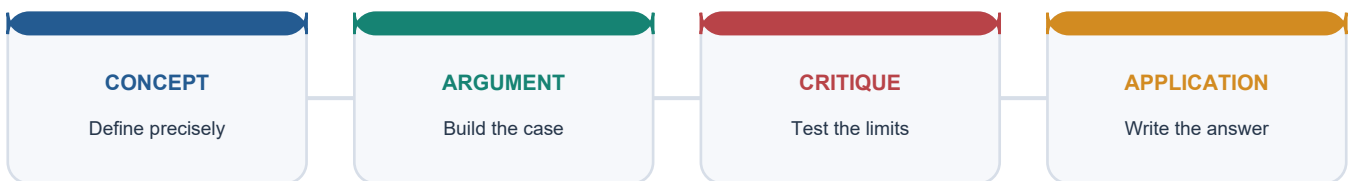


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Harappan Civilization: Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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The Harappan Civilization: Solved Practice Workbook

Exact practice contract: 32 original hard MCQs appear before PYQs; keys rotate A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times; 128 option explanations and 32 traps are unique. Verified PYQs preserve official-key status. Six original Mains models are independently word-counted.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

Correct options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D, repeated eight times. The 128 option explanations and 32 traps are individually worded and question-specific.

Q1

With reference to Harappan chronology, consider the following statements:

1. The Mature Harappan phase is conventionally placed c. 2600-1900 BCE.
2. The Early Harappan phase represents regional and proto-urban development.
3. The Late Harappan phase is best treated as an interval without settlement continuity.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 2 and 3 only

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 2 fit the process model. Statement 3 fails because Late Harappan communities and regional traditions continued even as urban integration changed.

Examiner trap 1: Treat phase labels as archaeological processes, not ethnic replacements.

Q2

Which one of the following pairs is correctly matched?

- A. Kalibangan - Dancing Girl figurine
- B. Dholavira - reservoirs and a distinctive tripartite plan
- C. Lothal - giant signboard
- D. Harappa - Great Bath

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Kalibangan - Dancing Girl figurine" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.
- **B:** Correct: Dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Lothal - giant signboard" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappa - Great Bath" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira is the reservoir/signboard/tripartite-plan anchor. Great Bath belongs to Mohenjo-daro, Kalibangan to ploughed field/fire installations, and the giant signboard is Dholavira, not Lothal.

Examiner trap 2: Do not move Dholavira's reservoirs or signboard to another site.

Q3

Consider the following site-feature pairs:

1. Mohenjo-daro - Great Bath
2. Kalibangan - ploughed-field evidence
3. Chanhudaro - specialised craft production

How many of the pairs given above are correctly matched?

- A. Only two
- B. Only one
- C. All three
- D. None

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Only two" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Only one" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.
- **C:** Correct: All three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "None" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are high-yield associations. Their value lies in the pair: Mohenjo-daro-water structure, Kalibangan-farming surface and Chanhudaro-craft, not in a detached site list.

Examiner trap 3: A three-pair question is lost by one swapped site-feature association.

Q4

Which one of the following is the most appropriate inference from shared brick conventions, weights and seals across many Mature Harappan settlements?

- A. They prove a deciphered imperial law code.
- B. They prove the presence of coinage.
- C. They prove every settlement had the same layout.
- D. They indicate wide shared norms and coordination, while the exact political mechanism remains debated.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "They prove a deciphered imperial law code." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "They prove the presence of coinage." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "They prove every settlement had the same layout." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.
- **D:** Correct: Material standardisation strongly supports integration and coordination. It does not supply a translated law code, make regional plans identical, or establish coinage or a named empire.

Examiner trap 4: Standardisation supports coordination but does not decipher an imperial constitution.

Q5

The Great Bath is especially useful in a Harappan architecture answer because it provides evidence for

- A. water-related public or collective built form at Mohenjo-daro
- B. a translated ritual doctrine
- C. a securely identified royal palace at Harappa
- D. a universal three-part town plan

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a translated ritual doctrine" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "a securely identified royal palace at Harappa" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a universal three-part town plan" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that its structure and water-related construction are secure observations. Palace, doctrine and universal-plan claims exceed what the feature itself establishes.

Examiner trap 5: Great Bath proves waterproof collective architecture, not a named creed.

Q6

Why is Dholavira particularly important for correcting a simplistic account of Harappan town planning?

- A. It contains the Great Bath.
- B. Its tripartite plan and reservoirs show regional variation within broader urban coordination.
- C. It proves that all Harappan settlements were coastal ports.
- D. It alone has evidence of any water management.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "It contains the Great Bath." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.

- **B:** Correct: Dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "It proves that all Harappan settlements were coastal ports." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "It alone has evidence of any water management." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that dholavira combines major water structures with a distinctive tripartite plan. It does not monopolise Harappan water management, turn every settlement into a port, or contain Mohenjo-daro's Great Bath.

Examiner trap 6: Dholavira corrects the universal two-part-city stereotype.

Q7

Consider the following statements about Harappan drainage:

1. Household drains, wells and street drains are material evidence for planned built practice.
2. Their presence directly identifies the title of the authority that maintained them.
3. Their layout can support an inference of recurring civic maintenance.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.
- **C:** Correct: Statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 are defensible. Drainage can demonstrate coordinated maintenance, but archaeology does not provide the office or title of a ruler or administrator.

Examiner trap 7: Drainage reveals maintenance needs, not the title of the maintaining authority.

Q8

With reference to functional labels in Harappan archaeology, which one of the following is correct?

- A. 'Granary' establishes that a building stored state tax in grain.
- B. The basin at Lothal has been conclusively translated as a harbour.
- C. 'Citadel' is a Harappan word preserved in inscriptions.
- D. Terms such as 'dockyard' and 'granary' are conventional interpretations that must be tested against context.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "'Granary' establishes that a building stored state tax in grain." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that these are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "The basin at Lothal has been conclusively translated as a harbour." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that these are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "'Citadel' is a Harappan word preserved in inscriptions." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that these are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.
- **D:** Correct: These are modern functional labels, not self-descriptions in a readable script. The underlying structures matter, but their exact purpose remains open to contextual reassessment.

Examiner trap 8: Granary, dockyard and citadel are analytical labels, not readable Harappan nouns.

Q9

Which one of the following combinations best represents a Harappan economic foundation?

- A. agriculture and pastoral resources linked to specialised craft and exchange
- B. only long-distance trade, with no local production
- C. temple estates linked to deciphered tax records
- D. iron smelting linked to punch-marked coinage

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "only long-distance trade, with no local production" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "temple estates linked to deciphered tax records" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "iron smelting linked to punch-marked coinage" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that urban production depended on food, fibre and animal resources, specialised craft and networks of exchange. Iron, coinage and readable tax records do not belong to this evidentiary profile.

Examiner trap 9: Long-distance trade supplemented; it did not replace agriculture and pastoral supply.

Q10

Which one of the following is correctly associated with Harappan textile production?

- A. punch-marked coins and guild seals
- B. spindle whorls, textile impressions and cotton production
- C. Roman amphorae and glass blowing
- D. Iron sickles and silk looms

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "punch-marked coins and guild seals" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.

- **B:** Correct: Spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Roman amphorae and glass blowing" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Iron sickles and silk looms" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that spindle whorls and textile impressions support spinning/weaving, while cotton is a signature association. The other options introduce later or unrelated material worlds.

Examiner trap 10: Cotton and spindle whorls belong to production evidence, not later guild records.

Q11

Consider the following statements:

1. Standard weights and scales support the inference of regular measurement in exchange.
2. Their use proves that Harappans used minted coinage.
3. Weights can be discussed with seals and craft production as parts of an integrated economy.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.
- **C:** Correct: Statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that statements 1 and 3 connect measurement to production and exchange. No coinage is known, so statement 2 substitutes a later economic form for the actual evidence.

Examiner trap 11: Weights are evidence of metrology, not minted coinage.

Q12

Mesopotamian references to Meluhha, Dilmun and Magan are most useful for establishing

- A. that Harappan script has been deciphered in Mesopotamia
- B. that Dilmun was a Harappan capital
- C. that all Harappan trade was controlled by one king
- D. long-distance exchange links, while exact routes, volumes and control remain qualified

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "that Harappan script has been deciphered in Mesopotamia" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.

- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "that Dilmun was a Harappan capital" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "that all Harappan trade was controlled by one king" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.
- **D:** Correct: The terms support external connections and procurement/exchange networks. They do not translate the Indus script, identify a capital or reveal one settled political authority.

Examiner trap 12: Meluhha supports contact; it does not disclose one king's trade monopoly.

Q13

In Mesopotamian textual references, Meluhha is conventionally connected in UPSC preparation with

- A. the Indus/Harappan world or a wider eastern zone
- B. a Harappan name for Dholavira alone
- C. the Vedic kingdom of Kuru
- D. a Roman port on the Red Sea

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a Harappan name for Dholavira alone" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "the Vedic kingdom of Kuru" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a Roman port on the Red Sea" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that meluhha is the key term for the Indus-related eastern exchange sphere. Its precise geographical reach remains debated, so it should not be reduced to one city.

Examiner trap 13: Do not shrink Meluhha to one city or equate it with a later kingdom.

Q14

Which one of the following statements about Harappan script is most accurate?

- A. It is conclusively Brahmi written only left to right.
- B. It is undeciphered; short inscriptions and seal context can be analysed without claiming a translation.
- C. It has yielded a continuous historical chronicle.
- D. It provides king-lists comparable to Mesopotamia.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "It is conclusively Brahmi written only left to right." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.
- **B:** Correct: The script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "It has yielded a continuous historical chronicle." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no

secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.

- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "It provides king-lists comparable to Mesopotamia." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the script remains undeciphered. Direction, sign patterns and contexts can be studied, but no secure translation, king-list or continuous historical text is available.

Examiner trap 14: Patterned signs can be studied while the script remains undeciphered.

Q15

Seals and sealings are most cautiously used by historians to discuss

- A. a complete Harappan epic tradition
- B. a securely known caste code
- C. administrative, ownership-related or transactional practices inferred from context
- D. the personal beliefs of every household

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "a complete Harappan epic tradition" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a securely known caste code" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.
- **C:** Correct: Seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "the personal beliefs of every household" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that seals are strongly connected to repeated symbols and possible administrative/transactional practices. Their context does not directly deliver literature, universal personal belief or a caste code.

Examiner trap 15: Seals permit administrative hypotheses, not a recovered caste code.

Q16

Which one of the following is the safest statement regarding Harappan religious interpretation?

- A. The horned seal figure is securely identified as Shiva.
- B. Fire installations prove a uniform state religion.
- C. Female figurines conclusively prove one Mother Goddess cult.
- D. Figurines, motifs and installations indicate possible ritual practices, but names and doctrines remain unsettled.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "The horned seal figure is securely identified as Shiva." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Fire installations prove a uniform state religion." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Female figurines conclusively prove one Mother Goddess cult." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.
- **D:** Correct: Material objects can show repeated symbols and possible ritual activity. The familiar deity labels and a single uniform creed go beyond the undeciphered archaeological record.

Examiner trap 16: Iconography must be described before a later deity-name is proposed.

Q17

The absence of unambiguous palaces, royal tombs and monumental temples is most relevant to which conclusion?

- A. the exact form of Harappan polity and state religion remains debated
- B. Harappans did not build substantial structures
- C. all settlements were politically independent villages
- D. Harappans had no organised civic life

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappans did not build substantial structures" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "all settlements were politically independent villages" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappans had no organised civic life" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that absence of these particular indicators limits reconstruction of rulers and doctrine. It does not erase strong evidence for cities, water systems, craft or broader coordination.

Examiner trap 17: Absence of royal tombs limits polity claims; it does not erase organised urban life.

Q18

Which one of the following best reflects the range of Harappan polity models?

- A. a modern parliamentary federation
- B. centralised state, city-states, or decentralised/corporate elite networks
- C. A known hereditary monarchy only
- D. no social coordination of any kind

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "a modern parliamentary federation" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.
- **B:** Correct: The material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "A known hereditary monarchy only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "no social coordination of any kind" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the material record permits several models of authority. A precise monarchy is not documented, while standardisation makes total absence of coordination implausible.

Examiner trap 18: Keep several polity models open while identifying the shared coordination evidence.

Q19

Consider the following statements about social inference:

1. Variation in house size may suggest unequal access to resources.
2. House size alone proves a fixed caste system.
3. Burial and household evidence require context and comparison before social conclusions are drawn.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 3
- B. 1 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 2 and 3 only

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1, 2 and 3" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.
- **C:** Correct: Variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that variation may support a cautious inequality inference, and context is essential. A fixed caste system cannot be read directly from house size or burial variation.

Examiner trap 19: House size and grave goods suggest difference but do not directly prove caste.

Q20

Which one of the following is least compatible with the current explanation of Harappan decline?

- A. Late Harappan continuities in changed settings
- B. regional variation in change after c. 1900 BCE
- C. interaction of environmental, exchange and internal factors
- D. a single universally proven invasion event that explains every region

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Late Harappan continuities in changed settings" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "regional variation in change after c. 1900 BCE" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "interaction of environmental, exchange and internal factors" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.
- **D:** Correct: The last claim is an old monocausal caricature. Evidence supports uneven de-urbanisation and several possible interacting pressures, not one universally proven event.

Examiner trap 20: Reject single-event extinction narratives and test regional sequences.

Q21

The phrase 'de-urbanisation with continuity' is preferred because it

- A. recognises changed urban traits while retaining Late Harappan communities and practices
- B. treats chronology as irrelevant
- C. denies that any urban features changed
- D. means every city remained unchanged after 1900 BCE

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: It captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "treats chronology as irrelevant" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "denies that any urban features changed" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "means every city remained unchanged after 1900 BCE" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it captures both transformation and persistence. It avoids the false choices of total extinction and complete urban continuity.

Examiner trap 21: Deurbanisation includes loss and continuity; it is not unchanged city life.

Q22

Which one of the following is a defensible use of river/environmental evidence in explaining Harappan change?

- A. It proves the identity of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati.
- B. It may be a contributing factor whose relevance must be bounded by region, chronology and other evidence.
- C. It makes trade and internal change irrelevant.
- D. A river shift conclusively explains every Harappan settlement.

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "It proves the identity of the Ghaggar-Hakra with the Vedic Sarasvati." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.
- **B:** Correct: Environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "It makes trade and internal change irrelevant." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "A river shift conclusively explains every Harappan settlement." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that environmental evidence is important but site- and region-specific. It cannot independently settle river identity or replace economic and social explanations.

Examiner trap 22: Environmental mechanisms require region, date and a non-environmental comparison.

Q23

Consider the following statements regarding Late Harappan developments:

1. Urban traits weakened unevenly after c. 1900 BCE.
2. Regional material traditions became more prominent.
3. Agricultural diversification and settlement shifts are relevant to the phase.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 2 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.
- **C:** Correct: All three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three describe localisation/de-urbanisation as a process. They are why Late Harappan should not be equated with an empty post-collapse interval.

Examiner trap 23: Late Harappan means localisation with continuing communities, not an empty interval.

Q24

Which one of the following site-location statements is correct?

- A. Kalibangan is a coastal site in Gujarat.
- B. Harappa lies on the Indus in Sindh.
- C. Mohenjo-daro lies in the Rann of Kutch.
- D. Rakhigarhi is in Haryana and Dholavira is in Kutch, Gujarat.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Kalibangan is a coastal site in Gujarat." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Harappa lies on the Indus in Sindh." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Mohenjo-daro lies in the Rann of Kutch." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.
- **D:** Correct: Rakhigarhi-Haryana and Dholavira-Kutch is a reliable map pair. Harappa is on the Ravi, Mohenjo-daro is in Sindh on the Indus, and Kalibangan is in Rajasthan.

Examiner trap 24: Rakhigarhi is in Haryana and Dholavira in Kutch; map pairs before features.

Q25

Which one of the following correctly describes the Harappan civilisation?

- A. a Bronze Age urban culture with wide regional extent beyond the Indus valley
- B. a literate culture whose script is fully deciphered
- C. an Iron Age culture limited to the middle Ganga plain
- D. a civilisation documented mainly by royal chronicles

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: It is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "a literate culture whose script is fully deciphered" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "an Iron Age culture limited to the middle Ganga plain" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a civilisation documented mainly by royal chronicles" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that it is a Bronze Age archaeological civilisation with a large multi-regional spread. Iron, readable royal chronicles and a deciphered script are incorrect substitutions.

Examiner trap 25: Harappan is Bronze Age and multi-regional, not Iron Age or Ganga-only.

Q26

The Mohenjo-daro Dancing Girl is most directly used in UPSC preparation to identify

- A. a Vedic sacrificial ritual
- B. bronze casting and material culture
- C. iron casting
- D. a royal portrait with known inscription

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "a Vedic sacrificial ritual" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.
- **B:** Correct: The figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "iron casting" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a royal portrait with known inscription" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the figurine is bronze and is a material-culture/craft association. It does not itself supply a religious text, royal identity or an iron technology claim.

Examiner trap 26: The named Dancing Girl is bronze; terracotta figurines are a distractor family.

Q27

Which one of the following sets contains only Harappan evidence commonly used for specialised production or measurement?

- A. ploughed field, horse stirrup, iron ploughshare
- B. Ashokan pillar, seal of a guild, Roman amphora
- C. bead workshops, spindle whorls, standard weights/scales
- D. Brahmi inscription, punch-marked coin, glass bead

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "ploughed field, horse stirrup, iron ploughshare" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Ashokan pillar, seal of a guild, Roman amphora" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.
- **C:** Correct: Bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "Brahmi inscription, punch-marked coin, glass bead" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that bead-work, spinning tools and weights/scales fit Harappan production and measurement. Other sets mix in later historical material or a non-characteristic technology.

Examiner trap 27: Separate Harappan workshop/measurement objects from later coins and inscriptions.

Q28

A candidate writes: 'The Harappan citadel proves a centralised monarchy.' Which revision is most evidence-sensitive?

- A. Use the Dancing Girl as proof of monarchy.
- B. Replace 'citadel' with 'temple' and retain the conclusion.
- C. Add that all cities had identical citadels.
- D. State that raised/planned sectors and standardisation indicate coordination, while the form of authority remains debated.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "Use the Dancing Girl as proof of monarchy." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "Replace 'citadel' with 'temple' and retain the conclusion." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "Add that all cities had identical citadels." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.
- **D:** Correct: The revision separates secure built evidence from the unsettled political mechanism. The other versions merely change labels or add irrelevant artefacts without solving the inference problem.

Examiner trap 28: Replace 'citadel proves monarchy' with 'raised sector indicates organisation, function debated'.

Q29

Which one of the following claims rests on the strongest category of Harappan evidence?

- A. covered drains and wells indicate developed water-related built practice
- B. the horned seal identifies a named deity
- C. a large building proves its use as a state granary
- D. a figurine proves universal female religious authority

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: Construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.

- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "the horned seal identifies a named deity" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "a large building proves its use as a state granary" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "a figurine proves universal female religious authority" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that construction and water features are directly observable. The deity, social and functional claims require additional interpretation and cannot be treated as equally secure.

Examiner trap 29: Choose direct built evidence over named-deity or social-system speculation.

Q30

For a 150-word answer on Harappan architecture, which sequence is most effective?

- A. religious labels -> a list of every site -> conclusion
- B. planned layout and building technology -> water/drainage -> named regional example -> functional-label caution
- C. one claim about an emperor -> an unqualified verdict
- D. modern conservation news -> dynasty list -> trade route

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "religious labels -> a list of every site -> conclusion" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.
- **B:** Correct: The second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "one claim about an emperor -> an unqualified verdict" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "modern conservation news -> dynasty list -> trade route" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the second sequence answers the directive with material evidence, regional variation and source criticism. It avoids unneeded catalogue, current-affairs decoration and a fictitious ruler.

Examiner trap 30: A 150-word architecture answer needs regional variation and label caution, not a site dump.

Q31

Consider the following statements:

1. Lothal is useful for bead-working and a basin conventionally identified as a dockyard.
2. Dholavira is useful for reservoirs and a large signboard.
3. Kalibangan is useful for a ploughed-field association.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1, 2 and 3
- D. 1 and 2 only

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "1 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is

interpretive.

- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "2 and 3 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.
- **C:** Correct: All three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.
- **D:** Incorrect: the claim "1 and 2 only" is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that all three are diagnostic site-feature associations. The wording 'conventionally identified' is important for Lothal's basin because function is interpretive.

Examiner trap 31: Lothal basin, Dholavira signboard and Kalibangan plough marks must stay distinct.

Q32

Which one of the following statements best distinguishes an observation from an inference?

- A. 'The script is translated' is observation, whereas a seal is an inference.
- B. 'The Harappans used drainage' is an inference, whereas 'they had an emperor' is observation.
- C. 'Mother Goddess' is a material observation, whereas a figurine is speculation.
- D. 'A seal carries a horned figure' is observation; identifying it as Pashupati is an interpretation.

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim "'The script is translated' is observation, whereas a seal is an inference." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim "'The Harappans used drainage' is an inference, whereas 'they had an emperor' is observation." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.
- **C:** Incorrect: the claim "'Mother Goddess' is a material observation, whereas a figurine is speculation." is the distractor in this item. The controlling distinction is that the image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.
- **D:** Correct: The image on the seal is observable; the deity identification is interpretive. This distinction is central wherever the unread script limits direct confirmation.

Examiner trap 32: Observation is the object or context; Pashupati, palace and empire are interpretations.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED ROUTED PYQS AND KEY DISCIPLINE

PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims 2019, GS-I, Q7

Question: Which one of the following is not a Harappan site?

- A. Chanhudaro
- B. Kot Diji
- C. Sohgaure
- D. Desalpur

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: C. Sohgaure.

Chanhudaro is a Harappan craft town, Kot Diji has Early and Mature Harappan levels, and Desalpur is a fortified Harappan site in Kutch. Sohgaure in Uttar Pradesh is associated with a later copper-plate inscription. The local official question paper is verified; the matching official answer key is unavailable locally, so the answer is not labelled official.

PYQ trap: A famous archaeological name is not automatically Harappan; classify period, region and assemblage.

PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims 2021, GS-I, Q32

Question: Which one of the following ancient towns is well-known for its elaborate system of water harvesting and management by building a series of dams and channelizing water into connected reservoirs?

- A. Dholavira
- B. Kalibangan
- C. Rakhigarhi
- D. Ropar

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A. Dholavira.

Dholavira used dams, channels and connected reservoirs in the seasonal Manhar-Mansar setting. Kalibangan is associated especially with a ploughed surface and fire installations; Rakhigarhi with a large Haryana urban complex; Ropar with a long cultural sequence. The official question is locally verified, but the corresponding official key is unavailable.

PYQ trap: Do not generalise all Harappan water systems from Dholavira; this question asks for the reservoir-dam complex.

PYQ 3 - UPSC Prelims 2025, GS-I, Q72

Question: The famous female figurine known as 'Dancing Girl', found at Mohenjo-daro, is made of

- A. carnelian
- B. clay
- C. bronze
- D. gold

OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCAL SET-A KEY: C. bronze.

The named figurine is a small bronze produced through lost-wax casting. Terracotta female figurines make clay a plausible distractor, but they are different objects. The locally held official 2025 Set-A key records C for Q72.

PYQ trap: Match the named object, not the broader material category of Harappan figurines.

PYQ 4 - UPSC Prelims 2026, GS-I, Q8

Question: Consider the following statements about archaeological findings in Harappan towns:

I. There is wide occurrence of spindle-whorls in houses but absence of spinning wheels. II. Weights and measurement scales, complete with graduations, have been discovered. III. Houses were built in large part with baked bricks around relatively spacious courtyards, with their own wells, bathing platforms and large rooms.

Which inferences can be drawn?

1. Statement I suggests that spinning was a laborious activity done at home.
 2. Statement II suggests the extent of scientific knowledge possessed by the Harappans.
 3. Statement III suggests the emergence of a common property system.
- A. 1 and 2 only
 - B. 2 and 3 only
 - C. 1 and 3 only
 - D. 1, 2 and 3

INFERRED ANSWER - PROVISIONAL KEY, NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: A. 1 and 2 only.

Household spindle-whorls support domestic manual spinning, and graduated weights/scales support developed measurement. House plans and private wells do not establish a legal common-property system. The locally held key is provisional; this solution remains explicitly inferred.

PYQ trap: An artefact can support an activity inference without proving a legal property regime.

PYQ 5 - UPSC Mains 2025, GS-I, Q1

Question: Discuss the salient features of the Harappan architecture. (Answer in 150 words.)

Demand: "Discuss" requires defining features, named examples, regional variation and a bounded conclusion.

Model answer: Harappan architecture combined civic coordination with regional adaptation. Planned streets, side-lane entrances and courtyard houses created ordered residential blocks. At Mohenjo-daro, wells, bathing floors and covered drains connected households to shared sanitation; the waterproof Great Bath demonstrates specialised collective construction. Standard mud and baked bricks, commonly using a 1:2:4 proportion in the Mature phase, enabled modular building. Yet plans varied: Dholavira used stone, multiple enclosed sectors and reservoirs adapted to seasonal streams, while Kalibangan had different wastewater arrangements. Lothal's brick basin and Harappa's large storage-related buildings indicate specialised functions, but labels such as "dockyard", "granary" and "citadel" remain archaeological interpretations. Thus Harappan architecture was planned, water-conscious and technically standardised, but regionally diverse and textually anonymous.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive with construction, domestic form, water, public works, four named sites, variation and source criticism within the required limit.

SIX ORIGINAL MAINS QUESTIONS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain how Dholavira modifies the conventional picture of Harappan town planning. (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (102 words):

Dholavira modifies the conventional model by showing that Harappan cities did not follow one Indus-core plan. Located on Khadir island in Kutch, it used extensive stone construction, several enclosed sectors and a large signboard rather than a simple universal citadel-lower-town division. Dams and channels drew seasonal water from the Manhar-Mansar setting into reservoirs and cisterns, making water storage part of the city's spatial design. These features demonstrate shared Harappan capacities for planning, measurement and public labour, but also strong regional adaptation to material and hydrological conditions. Dholavira therefore supports coordinated diversity: it belongs firmly to Mature Harappan urbanism while disproving architectural uniformity.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

Why this earns marks: It directly contrasts a common template with precise Dholavira evidence and ends with a qualified civilisational inference.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Why must religious interpretations of Harappan objects remain cautious? (Answer in 150 words.)

Model answer (108 words):

Harappan religion is reconstructed without a deciphered text. The horned seated figure, varied female figurines, pipal and animal motifs, fire installations, burials and the Great Bath can indicate symbolic or ritual practices. However, names such as Pashupati and Mother Goddess project later categories onto objects whose contemporary meanings are unknown. Fire features may be domestic, industrial or ritual, and a waterproof public bath does not by itself reveal doctrine. A sound interpretation therefore separates observation from inference: describe form, context and repetition; compare alternatives; then state confidence. The evidence supports ritual diversity, but not a securely named pantheon, uniform state religion or unbroken continuity with later Hindu practice.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

Why this earns marks: It uses named evidence, explains the source problem and provides an executable inference rule.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Analyse the relationship between Harappan cities, rural production, craft specialisation and labour. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (151 words):

Harappan urbanism functioned through an interdependent settlement hierarchy. Villages, farms and pastoral zones supplied grain, fibre, livestock and labour; quarry, mining and coastal zones supplied stone, metals and shell. Cities and specialist centres converted these inputs into beads, seals, faience, textiles, pottery and copper-bronze objects. Chanhudaro demonstrates concentrated craft without a conventional citadel, while Lothal links workshops, measurement and a large basin to exchange. Shortugai shows procurement reach toward highland mineral corridors. Standard weights, repeated seal forms and transport by carts, river craft and coastal routes made dispersed production comparable and movable. Public works at Mohenjo-daro and Dholavira also required brick-making, construction and recurring maintenance labour.

Yet archaeology cannot identify the legal status of workers or the exact balance among household production, attached specialists, market exchange and redistribution. The evidence therefore supports organised, differentiated labour within a connected urban-rural economy, not a self-sufficient city or a fully reconstructed state labour code.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

Why this earns marks: It connects settlement levels through flows of material and labour, uses three distinct sites and qualifies institutional reconstruction.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Does Harappan standardisation prove a centralised empire? Discuss. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (151 words):

Standardised weights, seals, brick proportions and aspects of urban planning show remarkable integration across the Mature Harappan world. Cubical weights enabled comparable quantities; common seal practices supported communication or transactions; modular bricks aided construction; and major water works indicate organised labour. Such regularity makes sustained coordination undeniable.

It does not, however, identify the political mechanism. Dholavira's stone-built multi-sector plan, Kalibangan's distinct drainage and Chanhudaro's specialist form show regional variation within the shared system. More importantly, the undeciphered script has yielded no secure king-list, dynasty or administrative constitution, while no unambiguous palace, royal tomb or monumental temple identifies a ruling house.

Three models therefore remain open: a centralised state, several regional states or city-states, and corporate or decentralised elites linked by shared institutions and exchange. Standardisation is evidence of capacity and norm enforcement, but not a signature unique to empire. The most defensible verdict is strong civilisational coordination with unresolved political form.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

Why this earns marks: It weighs the positive evidence for authority against the missing discriminators and evaluates competing models.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Critically examine the decline of Harappan urbanism as a multi-causal regional transformation. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (187 words):

After about 1900 BCE, the integrated urban system weakened unevenly rather than disappearing in one catastrophe. Large cities contracted or were abandoned; script, seals, long-distance standards and some specialised crafts declined; settlement patterns and pottery traditions became more regional.

Several mechanisms may have interacted. River movement and recurrent flooding affected particular settlements; weakening monsoons or aridity raised agricultural and water risk; changes in Gulf-Mesopotamian exchange reduced some external demand; and internal political-economic reorganisation may have undermined institutions that coordinated labour and circulation. None explains every region. A palaeoclimate proxy has a scale and date, and the Ghaggar-Hakra/Sarasvati identification is separate from demonstrating its effect on a settlement. The invasion model also lacks evidence for one conquering event that destroyed the civilisation.

The Late Harappan record supplies the necessary qualification. Communities continued in smaller or shifted settlements, agriculture diversified, and selected pottery, craft and subsistence practices persisted, even as cities, writing and integrated standards diminished.

Thus "decline" means regionally varied deurbanisation and localisation: major institutional discontinuity combined with demographic and cultural continuity. A good explanation connects cause, local mechanism, chronology and response instead of listing universal theories.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

Why this earns marks: It is genuinely critical: it tests each cause, states scale limits, explains outcomes and reconciles discontinuity with continuity.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Evaluate what archaeology and scientific evidence can-and cannot-tell us about Harappan society and legacy. (Answer in 250 words.)

Model answer (199 words):

Archaeology reconstructs Harappan life most securely through material practices. Houses, drains and reservoirs reveal construction and maintenance; crop, animal and residue evidence reconstruct diet; workshops and provenance identify production and exchange; burials and skeletal study illuminate mortuary treatment, health and mobility. Radiocarbon dating refines chronology, while isotopes and ancient DNA can test bounded questions about movement and ancestry.

These methods also impose limits. Unequal houses or grave goods may indicate differentiated access, but do not directly prove caste, slavery or a complete class hierarchy. Figurines and seals may preserve ritual imagery, but cannot name deities while the script remains undeciphered. The published Rakhigarhi genome concerns one context-specific individual; it cannot identify the language, religion or total ancestry of every Harappan population. Environmental proxies likewise require regional and chronological matching.

Legacy should therefore be divided into continuity and discontinuity. Crops, craft knowledge, rural settlement and some symbols or practices may continue through regional interaction, while urban scale, script, seals and integrated standardisation clearly declined.

Scientific evidence makes Harappan history more precise by narrowing claims, not by authorising total identities. The defensible legacy is selective continuity through transformed communities, not an unchanged civilisation or a biological verdict on language and culture.

Claim -> evidence -> analysis -> qualification check: The model makes a direct claim, links named archaeological evidence to its implication, and marks the boundary of the inference before the verdict.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes methods by question, uses concrete evidence, states sample limits and gives a balanced legacy conclusion.